



A STUDY COMPANION

The Confident Mirror

A Battle-Tested Guide to Unshakable Performance

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IMPORTANT INSIGHTS + ACTION GUIDE

The heart of the book

Confidence you can build on purpose

THE CENTRAL QUESTION How do you perform at your very best when it matters most — and is confidence something you can build on purpose, or just a gift some people are born with?

THE AUTHOR'S ANSWER Confidence is not a mood, a personality trait, or a gift. It is a sense of certainty about your ability that you manufacture by how you think. Zinsser calls the moment you achieve it “the First Victory” — the inner win that must come before any outer one. You earn it by deliberately managing what you deposit into a psychological “bank account”: filtering your memories, choosing your self-talk, and rehearsing your future in vivid detail. You protect that account against setbacks and your own doubt. And when it is time to perform, you stop building and simply spend what you have. Confidence has almost nothing to do with what happens to you, and almost everything to do with how you think about what happens to you.

The framework

THE FIRST VICTORY Sun Tzu: victorious warriors win first, then go to war. The inner victory of certainty precedes the outer victory in the arena.

THE PSYCHOLOGICAL BANK ACCOUNT Confidence is a running balance. Memories of effort, success, and progress are deposits; replayed setbacks and imagined failures are withdrawals. You control the ledger.

FOUR MOVEMENTS Understand what confidence really is, then BUILD the account, PROTECT it, and SPEND it when you step into your arena.

I

The First Victory

WHAT CONFIDENCE ACTUALLY IS

Confidence is manufactured certainty, not swagger — and
entirely in how you think. Before you can build it, you must
with four facts of being human you cannot change.

Key insights

Confidence is manufactured certainty, not swagger

Zinsser rejects vague definitions like “believing in yourself.” His working definition is precise: confidence is a sense of certainty about your ability that lets you bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously. You already do this every day — you tie your shoes and brush your teeth with total confidence, never analyzing the steps. Real confidence in high-stakes moments is that same quiet, automatic certainty, not a loud emotional state.

WHY IT MATTERS Naming confidence correctly changes what you work on. If confidence is certainty that quiets analysis, then the goal is not to feel pumped up but to reduce mental chatter so your trained skill can come out cleanly. Overthinking, not under-feeling, is the enemy.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE A psychology professor’s illustration: if you had to consciously think about exactly what both knees were doing while hurrying down a staircase, you’d likely end up in a heap at the bottom. Skilled action runs best when deliberate analysis steps aside.

WHAT IT CHANGES You measure readiness by how quiet and automatic you feel, not how excited. Before performing you aim to think less, not harder.

REMEMBER *Certainty that silences thought — not swagger — is what lets your best come out.*

It's how you think about what happens, not what happens

The book's central truth. Two performers can face the same event — a win, a loss, a bad warm-up — and walk away with opposite levels of confidence, because confidence is the running total of your thoughts about yourself and your situation. Zinsser frames this as a psychological bank account: memories of effort, success, and progress are deposits; replaying setbacks and dreading the future are withdrawals. You decide, moment by moment, which to make.

WHY IT MATTERS This hands you control. You cannot always change events, but you can always choose how you interpret and store them — what Viktor Frankl, surviving the camps, called the last of the human freedoms: to choose one's attitude in any circumstance. Confidence stops being luck and becomes a practice.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Michael Strahan had ten sacks in ten games yet felt he “sucked,” because his dominant mental image was of failing to reach the quarterback. Ilya Kulik had a terrible Olympic warm-up yet skated a gold-medal short program, because he refused to replay it and thought only of nailing each jump. Same kind of situation; opposite thinking; opposite result.

WHAT IT CHANGES You start auditing your inner ledger: which thoughts am I depositing, which am I withdrawing? You treat every event as raw material you get to interpret.

REMEMBER *Your confidence is a bank account of thoughts — and you hold the pen.*

The mind-body loop is always running: sewer or success

Thoughts shape feelings, feelings shape your physical state, your physical state shapes execution — and the result becomes the next thought. This loop runs twenty-four hours a day. Zinsser names the two directions the “sewer cycle” (worry □ tension, tunnel vision, stress chemistry □ worse performance) and the “success cycle” (constructive thoughts □ energy, open vision □ better performance). There is no neutral: the loop is always either helping or hurting.

WHY IT MATTERS Because there is no neutral ground, drifting is not free — an unmanaged mind defaults toward the sewer. The person who deliberately chooses constructive thoughts more often, and especially at the moment of performance, gains a real physical edge in speed, vision, and coordination.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Decades of mind-body research (Herbert Benson's relaxation work, and the reverse studies on stress) show that changing how you think measurably changes heart rate, blood pressure, and muscle tension — for better or for worse.

WHAT IT CHANGES You notice which cycle you're on and steer toward curiosity — “let's see how well I can do this” — instead of dread.

REMEMBER *You're always on one of two cycles; choose the one that opens you up.*

Your butterflies are fuel, not fear

The racing heart, sweaty palms, and stomach flips before a big moment are not signs something is wrong. They are your autonomic nervous system dumping adrenaline — a custom-made, perfectly legal performance enhancer delivered at exactly the right time. The sensations of nervousness and excitement are biologically identical; only the story you tell about them differs.

WHY IT MATTERS Most performers misread arousal as a warning and slide into the sewer cycle. Reframing it as fuel converts the same physiology into an advantage. This wiring is 200,000 years old and never switches off, so fighting it is futile — befriending it is not.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Sprinter Michael Johnson, asked if his heart was pounding before an Olympic final, said yes — and then, “when I'm nervous, I'm comfortable.” Even Bill Belichick, after decades of coaching, admitted he still gets nervous before every game.

WHAT IT CHANGES When the nerves arrive you welcome them as a signal that something special is about to happen, rather than proof you're not ready.

REMEMBER *The nerves are the rocket fuel arriving on time — fall in love with your butterflies.*

Growth happens on the plateau, unseen

Practice does not pay off in a smooth upward line. Progress comes as long flat plateaus interrupted by sudden bursts — and, over time, the plateaus get longer and the bursts get smaller. The mistake is to read a plateau as proof you lack talent. In fact the real development is happening on the plateau: each quality repetition wraps another layer of myelin around the neural circuit, so the signal eventually runs faster and the breakthrough surfaces.

WHY IT MATTERS Believing improvement should be constant makes people quit during the exact stretch when the wiring is being built. Understanding the delayed, uneven return lets you keep depositing effort during the dry spells that break everyone else.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Educator George Leonard urged learners to “love the plateau,” because true mastery is built there. The neuroscience of myelin — insulation that can speed a nerve signal dramatically once thick enough — explains why the gains chain together silently before they show.

WHAT IT CHANGES You stop panicking during plateaus and start valuing them as your improvement factory. Consistency beats visible reward.

REMEMBER *You are getting better on the flat, even when nothing shows yet.*

II

Building the Account

DEPOSITS FROM PAST, PRESENT, AND FUTURE

You grow certainty by filtering your memories for what is
keeping, talking to yourself in the present as if the future
here, and rehearsing success and recovery in vivid, multi-
detail.

Key insights

Filter your past into deposits

You already run a mental filter that decides which experiences you keep and which you discard. Most people unconsciously keep their misses. Zinsser teaches you to reverse it — to deliberately retain moments of effort, success, and progress, and to release or restructure the rest. Three tools do the work: a Top 10 list of career highlights, a Daily ESP (one Effort, one Success, one Progress each day), and an Immediate Progress Review (locking in the best rep before moving to the next drill or task).

WHY IT MATTERS Whatever your conscious mind dwells on most is what your unconscious works toward, so you get more of it. Filtering in your best moments literally rehearses success and builds the balance you'll draw on when it counts.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Hall of Fame hitter Tony Gwynn edited video after every game into a file of solid contact and good decisions — and permanently deleted the file of bad ones, because the last thing he needed was to watch himself flail at a curveball.

WHAT IT CHANGES You end each day and each drill by asking “what did I get right?” instead of “what did I blow?”

REMEMBER *Keep the highlights; the science says you tend to repeat what you replay.*

Talk to yourself in the present, as if it's already true

The thousands of statements you make to yourself set a self-fulfilling prophecy in motion: what you believe about a situation drives the effort you give it, which produces the result that confirms the belief. An effective affirmation follows five rules — personal, present tense, positive, precise, and powerful — and describes what you want as if it is happening now, even for skills you don't yet have.

WHY IT MATTERS The brain doesn't cleanly separate a statement about the future from the reality it describes; phrasing goals in the present carves the neural pathways of success rather than reminding you of what you lack. Saying “yes” to the outcome you want is not lying — it's aiming.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Ranked seventh in the country, Alessandra Ross repeated “I run a one-fifty-six eight hundred” — six seconds faster than she'd ever run — every time she walked through a doorway, and set back-to-back personal bests at the Olympic Trials. Speed skater Dan Jansen wrote “I love the 1000” a dozen times a night for two years before his Olympic gold.

WHAT IT CHANGES You catch negative or future-tense self-talk and rephrase it in the present, positive, and precise — then repeat it often (a doorway, a nightly notebook, a recorded script).

REMEMBER *Say it in the present as if it's true; to affirm is to say yes.*

Envision it first — the nervous system can't tell rehearsed from real

Envisioning is the deliberate production of an emotionally powerful, multisensory experience of a desired future — not idle daydreaming. Done with control, rich detail, an internal (first-person) perspective, and genuine emotion, it fires the same neural pathways as the real action, wraps the same myelin, and rewrites your self-image. It also creates a “déjà vu” of success so the real moment feels familiar.

WHY IT MATTERS Because the body responds to vivid imagination almost as if it were real, mental reps improve skill, calm the physiology, and build certainty — all from a chair. Few competitors will spend fifteen minutes a day doing it, which is exactly why it separates them.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Imagine biting a lemon and you salivate, though there is no lemon — proof the nervous system obeys the image. Hammer thrower Jerry Ingalls got hundreds of perfect mental reps a week; Bianca Andreescu visualized beating Serena Williams the morning she did.

WHAT IT CHANGES You add a short daily envisioning session — a private mental room, an internal camera, full senses — to rehearse both skills and whole breakthrough performances.

REMEMBER *Live the win in vivid detail first; your nervous system will believe it.*

Rehearse the recovery, not just the win

The enemy always gets a vote, so a flawless plan will still meet surprises. The Flat Tire Drill is envisioning applied to trouble: you name a few likely setbacks, then rehearse a calm, successful response to each — stop the worry, breathe, take control, finish with success — spending at least three times as long on the recovery as on the problem. You install a mental subroutine before you need it.

WHY IT MATTERS Knowing you already have a rehearsed response to adversity keeps a surprise from draining your certainty. Like a driver who has changed a flat before, you meet the unexpected as a known problem, not a crisis.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE At the Olympic Trials someone secretly roughened Jerry Ingalls's throwing circle; rivals melted, but he'd rehearsed so many other recoveries that a surprise had no effect. Wrestler Phil Simpson sat calm through a five-minute TV timeout that cracked his opponent, thinking “I'm in total control.”

WHAT IT CHANGES Before a performance you list two or three plausible “flat tires” and rehearse getting back on the road, so nothing catches you flat-footed.

REMEMBER *Rehearse the pothole and the fix — then a surprise is just a known problem.*

III

Protecting the Account

DEFENDING CERTAINTY FROM SETBACKS AND DOUBT

Life hits back and your own mind attacks itself. Three sa
keep the balance from draining – and one of them lets it
while you are making mistakes.

Key insights

Shrink the setback: temporary, limited, non-representative

The second job of your filter is to restructure the bad, not just keep the good. When something goes wrong, explain it to yourself three ways: temporary (it happened that one time), limited (it happened in that one place), and non-representative (that's not really who I am). This is not denial — you still learn from the mistake — it's refusing to let one error metastasize into “here I go again,” “my whole day is ruined,” and “maybe I'm not good enough.”

WHY IT MATTERS Martin Seligman's research on explanatory style shows optimists treat bad events as temporary, limited, and external, while pessimists treat them as permanent, pervasive, and personal — and the pessimists quit more when adversity hits. How you explain a setback largely determines whether it drains you.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE A lacrosse goalie who gives up seven goals a game protects her confidence by treating each one as “just that one time.” A coach whose team kept dropping passes shouted “it's gotta be this ball,” launched it into the stands, and the team instantly returned to form — he pushed the failure outside them.

WHAT IT CHANGES After any miss you consciously label it temporary, limited, and non-representative, learn what you can, and let it go.

REMEMBER *Put the mistake in its box: it happened once, in one place, and it isn't you.*

Get in the last word on your own doubt

Negative self-talk is as damaging to the account as any real setback. Two voices compete for your mind, and whichever speaks last tends to win the moment. So you take three steps: acknowledge the negative thought (“okay, I hear you”), silence it (a firm internal “stop”, a mental stop sign or flush), and replace it with a helpful statement from your bank account. You do this again and again, like whack-a-mole, for as long as you compete.

WHY IT MATTERS Confidence is not the absence of doubt but the ongoing resistance to it. Champions hear the same fearful voices as everyone — they just treat each one as a cue to replace, not obey.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE In a study, cyclists who practiced motivational self-talk lasted 18% longer to exhaustion and felt better doing it. Endurance writer Alex Hutchinson, after decades of scoffing, concluded the single biggest advice he'd give his younger self was to train self-talk with diligence. Arthur Ashe and Bobby Jones each admitted to fearful thoughts before winning.

WHAT IT CHANGES The instant a doubt arrives you name it, cut it off, and swap in a prepared affirmation or highlight — rather than letting it run.

REMEMBER *Whoever speaks last wins the moment — make sure it's your conviction.*

The shooter's mentality: gain confidence while missing

The most aggressive safeguard turns setbacks into fuel. The shooter's mentality holds two “illogical” beliefs at once: every miss makes the next shot more likely to go in, and every make means more makes are coming. Misses are read as temporary and limited but also as a sign you're “due”; makes are read as permanent and universal. It isn't statistically sound — but it manufactures certainty at the moment of truth, which is what gives you your best chance.

WHY IT MATTERS Ordinary logic says a slump predicts more slump, which invites tension and worse play. The shooter's mentality refuses that story and keeps you loose and eager exactly when it's hardest.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Steph Curry, per coach Steve Kerr, simply knows that if he misses he'll make the next one. Thomas Edison treated thousands of failed tests as information bringing him closer. College athlete Stuart Anderson, one for fourteen, demanded the last shot — “I'm due to get one in” — and sank it.

WHAT IT CHANGES You reframe each miss as “the next one's coming” and each make as “I'm hot,” keeping momentum on your side no matter the scoreboard.

REMEMBER *Misses make the next hit likelier; hits make more hits — keep shooting.*

IV

Spending It in the Arena

TURNING PREPARATION INTO PERFORMANCE

A pregame routine opens the vault; a short in-the-moment keeps it open, engagement by engagement. You stop being saver and become a confident spender.

Key insights

Decide you are enough, and become a spender

A pregame routine has three parts: take stock of yourself (read your journals and highlights — your account balance), take stock of the situation (the real task is to stay present moment-to-moment, plus the hidden “flat tire” factors and the arena itself), and then make the crucial decision that you have enough and are enough. That decision flips you from a careful saver still acquiring skill to a carefree — not careless — spender releasing it.

WHY IT MATTERS You never learn how much you have until you empty your pockets. Waiting to feel fully prepared keeps confidence permanently out of reach, because there is always more you could have done. Certainty is a decision, not a finish line.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE Billy Mills reread a year of workout logs and concluded he could win Olympic gold — and did. Wrestler Helen Maroulis made “I am enough” her mantra before beating the most dominant wrestler in history: “you don’t have to be extraordinary... you can be a champion by just being enough.” Michael Phelps visibly “morphed” from laid-back into quiet predator at the wall.

WHAT IT CHANGES Before performing you review your evidence, name your risks, and then declare “I’m ready, I’m enough, let’s see how well I do with what I’ve got” — and switch to statements-only.

REMEMBER *Decide you are enough and spend freely — you never know your balance until you empty your pockets.*

In the moment: lose your mind and come to your senses (CBA)

Peak performance is marked by an economy of brain activity — a quiet mind and fully engaged senses. To reach it repeatedly across a long performance, use a short pre-engagement routine, CBA: Cue your conviction with a brief, powerful, present-tense statement; Breathe your body with a full down-and-out inhale and a settling exhale; Attach your attention by becoming fascinated with the one thing that matters right now. Run it before each rep, point, play, pitch, or meeting.

WHY IT MATTERS Thinking hard about mechanics or outcomes eats the mental bandwidth your senses need and cranks tension. CBA clears the mechanism and returns you to informed instinctiveness — knowing what to do because you've practiced, and doing it without interference.

IN PRACTICE, AN EXAMPLE A Ranger School candidate on his last chance told himself “it's on, dude, we're gonna dominate,” ran the raid in unconscious certainty, and earned the best-executed grade the instructors had seen. Bobsledder Doug Sharp added a fourth habit — scanning for “the slightest break” — and his team ended a 46-year U.S. medal drought.

WHAT IT CHANGES You build a personal CBA and repeat it before every engagement, resetting to a calm, alert, present state dozens of times a performance.

REMEMBER *Cue, breathe, attach — quiet the mind, wake the senses, and let it happen.*

Definitions & distinctions

Confidence

A sense of certainty about your ability that lets you bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously — knowing something so well you don't have to think about how to do it while doing it.

The First Victory

The inner victory of certainty, won before the outer contest. From Sun Tzu: victorious warriors win first, then go to war.

Confidence vs. competence

Competence is skill you've built; confidence is deciding to feel certain about whatever level of competence you have. You need both — and even high competence underperforms without the decision to trust it.

Striving vs. destructive perfectionism

Striving for perfection fuels effort; demanding perfection and punishing every miss drains confidence. Aim for excellence, not flawlessness — the highest achievers hold only moderate perfectionism.

Nervous vs. anxious

“Nervous” rightly means your nervous system is more active — adrenaline arriving to help. Anxiety is the fearful story you tell about that arousal. Same biology, different narrative.

Sewer cycle vs. success cycle

Two directions of the always-running thought–feeling–body–execution loop. Worry tightens and narrows you; constructive thought energizes and opens you.

Internal vs. external perspective

In envisioning, internal means seeing out of your own eyes (GoPro), which activates more muscle and emotion and is best for perfecting a skill; external means watching yourself from outside, useful mainly for beginners learning a new move.

Saver vs. spender / workhorse vs. racehorse

In preparation you're a careful saver and a methodical workhorse; at performance time you become a carefree-not-careless spender and a spirited racehorse, releasing what you built.

Constructive delusion

Holding a vivid belief in success you have not yet earned — as you did learning to ride a bike. A necessary, self-fulfilling kind of aiming, not denial.

The Statements-Only (SO) rule

Once game day arrives, or a set line is crossed, you stop asking questions of yourself or others (even “ready to go?”) and make only statements — questions invite doubt.

The toolkit

The practices

What to do, when to use it, and what to watch for.

The Top 10 List

DO Write your ten best moments in your chosen field — large or small — attach a photo, and post it where you'll see it.

WHEN As your first deposit, and to revisit whenever your balance feels low or before a big event.

SOLVES Forgetting your real evidence of ability and defining yourself by recent struggles.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You can recall your top moments easily and feel a lift of “big-fish” certainty when you do.

CAUTION Small accomplishments count — don't disqualify yourself by waiting for trophy-worthy ones.

The Daily ESP

DO Each day write one Effort, one Success, and one Progress (E, S, P) from your practice or workday — more if you find them.

WHEN End of day, or first thing about yesterday. Five minutes.

SOLVES Letting daily moments of effort, success, and progress pass unacknowledged and un-deposited.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE At least three fresh deposits a day, and a running highlight reel you can draw on later.

CAUTION If you “can't find” an E, S, or P, you're not looking closely enough — go hour by hour.

The Immediate Progress Review (IPR)

DO As you move from one drill or task to the next, lock in the single best rep of the one you just finished.

WHEN Continuously, throughout a practice or workday, between activities.

SOLVES Carrying your worst rep — not your best — into the next attempt.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE A dozen small highlights banked by day's end and a better overall session from staying in a good mood.

CAUTION Keep it brief — a still photo or short clip in the mind, then move on.

Affirmations (the five P's)

DO Compose statements that are Personal, Present-tense, Positive, Precise, and Powerful — for skills you have and ones you want.

WHEN Built once, then repeated many times a day.

SOLVES Self-talk that is impersonal, future-tense, or focused on what you want to avoid (which carves the wrong pathways).

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE Repeating one gives you a reassuring “I am enough” feeling.

CAUTION “I never miss” backfires — the brain hears “miss.” Phrase what you want (“my serve lands just inside the line”).

The Notebook Nightcap

DO Write each of your key affirmations at least three times in a notebook before bed, feeling each one.

WHEN Nightly, as the last thoughts of the day.

SOLVES Leaving your subconscious poor material to process overnight.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You fall asleep on personal, positive, powerful thoughts and wake more certain.

CAUTION Handwriting beats typing for memory; do it consistently, not once.

The Open Doorway

DO Every time you pass through any doorway, repeat your three key affirmations.

WHEN All day — doorways are constant triggers (easily dozens a day).

SOLVES Limiting affirmation to one moment, and letting doorways trigger worry instead.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE Hundreds of daily deposits; the self-image gradually becomes real.

CAUTION Discomfort at first is normal — “who am I to think that?” Answer: who are you not to?

The Macro Affirmation Script

DO Record a ten-minute, first-person, present-tense narration covering your key skills and mindset, over music.

WHEN As a daily ritual — on the way to practice, in pregame prep.

SOLVES Scattered self-talk with no sustained, immersive reinforcement.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You finish it “fired up” and eager to perform.

CAUTION Keep it about the process of great play, not just outcomes.

Breakthrough Envisioning (7 steps)

DO In a private mental room, envision a whole desired performance — arrive, warm up, start, hit the big moments, finish, celebrate — with control, full senses, internal perspective, and real emotion.

WHEN Daily, ~15–20 minutes; especially before a breakthrough opportunity.

SOLVES Stepping into a big new level feeling unfamiliar and uncertain.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE The real moment feels like déjà vu — “been there, done that.”

CAUTION If a mistake flashes, yell “cut,” reset the scene, and finish it the way you want.

The Flat Tire Drill

DO List a few likely setbacks; for each, rehearse stopping the worry, breathing, taking control, and finishing with success — spending 3x longer on the recovery than the problem.

WHEN As part of pregame preparation for anything high-stakes.

SOLVES A surprise derailing your certainty because you never rehearsed a response.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE Even an unforeseen setback feels handleable — “I could easily handle this one.”

CAUTION You can't rehearse every specific surprise; rehearsing many builds a general recovery reflex.

Temporary / Limited / Non-representative

DO Explain every setback three ways: it happened once, in one place, and it isn't the real you.

WHEN The instant a mistake or bad stretch occurs.

SOLVES One error snowballing into “here I go again □ the day's ruined □ maybe I'm not good enough.”

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You keep your balance (or grow it), learn the lesson, and move on clean.

CAUTION This is reinterpretation, not denial — still own the mistake and fix what's fixable.

Get in the Last Word

DO Acknowledge the doubt, silence it with a firm cue (“stop” / a stop sign / a flush), replace it with a prepared affirmation or highlight.

WHEN Every time negative self-talk arrives — expect to repeat it endlessly.

SOLVES Being a passive listener to your own fear, letting it speak last.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE Doubt still shows up, but conviction always gets the final word.

CAUTION Don't expect a permanent victory — it's whack-a-mole, and that's normal.

The Pregame Routine

DO Take stock of yourself (your balance), take stock of the situation (the real moment-to-moment task, your flat tires, the arena), then decide you are enough — and switch to statements only.

WHEN In the final stretch before any performance.

SOLVES Entering the arena distracted, unsure, and asking doubt-inviting questions.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You arrive present, purposeful, and certain — the workhorse becomes the racehorse.

CAUTION Get “attuned” to the arena in advance (visit, photos, or imagination) to remove surprise.

CBA Pre-Shot Routine

DO Before each engagement: Cue your conviction (short, powerful, present statement), Breathe your body (full down-and-out, settling exhale), Attach your attention (become fascinated with the one thing that matters now).

WHEN Before every rep, point, play, pitch, shift, or meeting.

SOLVES Sliding into over-analysis, worry, or self-criticism mid-performance.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You reset to calm, alert, present informed instinctiveness — repeatedly.

CAUTION Cue the process (“be a wall”), not the outcome (“don't let anyone score”); keep importance from over-inflating.

The After Action Review (AAR)

DO After performing, ask What happened? (facts and highlights), So what? (lessons), Now what? (statements + actions + envision next time).

WHEN Once you've cooled down, before the next opportunity.

SOLVES Rushing to the next event without extracting lessons or new deposits.

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE You end with renewed purpose, fresh affirmations, and a clear plan — and more in the account.

CAUTION After a loss, weight reflection ~80% highlights / 20% junk; after a win, tighten up to ~60/40.

QUICK REFERENCE

The whole system, one page

CONFIDENCE Confidence = certainty about your ability that lets you by execute unconsciously.

THE CORE It's how you think about what happens, not what happens. You of thoughts – you hold the pen.

BUILD THE ACCOUNT

- Filter the past: Top 10, Daily IPR
- Speak the present: affirmations, five P's
- Envision the future: private all senses
- Rehearse the recovery: Flat Drill

PROTECT THE ACCOUNT

- Sink setbacks: temporary, limited, non-representative
- Get in the last word: acknowledge, silence, replace
- Shooter's mentality: due for the next one
- Decide to be different from the crowd

SPEND IT IN THE ARENA

- Take stock of yourself and the situation
- Decide you are enough or saver to spender
- Statements only – no questions on game day
- CBA each engagement: Cue, Breathe, Attach

FOUR THINGS YOU CANNOT CHANGE

- The mind-body loop always runs – pick the success cycle
- You'll never be perfect – strive, don't demand
- Nerves are fuel – fall in love with your butterflies
- Growth happens on the plateau – keep depositing

Faith takes practice. If you're having a bad day, change your mind and have a go